

Soundcard: The Hidden Performer

A great deal depends on this rather neglected piece of hardware. Mostly it is the soundcard that is to blame for poor signal quality. Contrary to popular belief, a soundcard consumes resources too. More importantly, if you are going for a two-speaker setup (all of the two-speaker sets reviewed here had built-in amplifiers) then Creative Vibra 128 is the soundcard to go for. This soundcard is relatively inexpensive and although earlier it was bundled along with the multimedia kits from Creative, it is now separately available in the market for about Rs 1,200.

If you are planning to go in for the 4.1/5.1 speaker sets, then you need a soundcard that supports discrete channels (front and rear). A good choice would be the Creative SoundBlaster Live! series that

has support for four-point surround speaker sets and also includes several other features. There are three versions of the Sound Blaster Live!—Sound Blaster Live! Value, the SB Live! Platinum and the Sound Blaster Live! Platinum 5.1 (which now supports Dolby digital decoding).

The Sound Blaster Live! Value is one of the most popular soundcards in the market. It is especially known for its quality and also the minimal system CPU utilisation (less than 3 per cent). As a matter of fact, it uses the same core DSP (Digital Signal Processor) chipset (EMU10K1) which the other expensive versions of this card use. The SoundBlaster Live! Value is reasonably priced at Rs 3,400, whereas the Platinum and the Platinum 5.1, which include professional tools such as the Live!

drive are priced Rs 13,000. These fit in any empty bay on your cabinet on the front and furthers connectivity to various auxiliary devices.

However, there are other cheaper surround capable soundcards available. If you are not bothered about system CPU utilisation and an extensive software bundle, you can turn to soundcards that run using the CMI 8738 chipsets. Yamaha and Lancer have created their versions of the four-point surround cards using the CMI 8738 chipsets. However, the CPU utilisation is much higher than the SB Live! Series.

Aureal had created the Aureal Vortex and Vortex 2 Quad. But the firm being extinct, you will be lucky to find any of their cards.

right, centre, rear right, rear left, and a subwoofer that is capable of generating pure distortion-free bass. The 20 Watt RMS subwoofer, though low powered as compared to the Logitech Xtrusio DSR 100 which is equipped with a 52 Watt RMS subwoofer, delivered exceptional quality.

The Logitech DSR 100 took the second spot. This set has the most powerful subwoofer. Here we were able to get the best in the bass section with the heavy 52 Watt RMS bass. The letdown however was its satellites—they distort at high volumes.

The third player was the Jetway Artis 1200 Watt that had a good subwoofer (not as powerful as the Logitech) and satellites. The only flaw that we found here was the jarring/distortion of the front satellites at peak volumes. This could be the problem with the inbuilt amplifier that wasn't capable of stabilising the output to the front speakers.

The speaker that did the worst was the Turando FP2000 that sported the best looks and was the only flat panel 5.1 systems that we received. The looks, however, didn't match its performance. There was a lot of distortion audible from the satellite.

Gaming

In gaming, the speaker that came out a clear winner was the **Logitech Xtrusio DSR 100**. The speaker, with its low frequency generating subwoofer, can make you actually feel the vibrations. It is followed by the Creative DTT2500 and the

Frontech 5D-103 that with their respective systems did an amazing job. The only place where these speakers let us down was in bass reproduction where there was a significant lack of punch. Otherwise, any of these speakers would be a very good buy if you are interested in an enjoyable gaming experience.

Turando FP2000 was a disappointment once again—it delivered poor quality bass and very loud treble in *Unreal* and delivered a lot of distortion. While playing *Quake III Arena*, it delivered loud and screechy treble and mid frequency.

The Creative FPS 1000, the Jetway Artis and the Typhoon DS 1034 didn't perform badly but weren't impressive in any way either.

These speakers were capable of delivering an acceptable quality of sound while playing games. But they were not as good as the Logitech DSR 100 that tempted us

to go on for another round of frags in *Quake III*.

Music

For the best musical experience, check out the **Creative DTT2500** that delivered the best quality music without any distortion. The treble, mid and bass frequencies were balanced and well maintained.

In contrast to this, the Turando FP2000, like in the other tests, fared disappointingly here too with too much distortion. This distortion was mostly generated from the satellites due to the fact that these satellites were giving out bass, which is not good for any system.

The speakers that came close to the performance churned out by the Creative DTT2500 were the Logitech Xtrusio DSR 100 and the Creative FPS 1000. These systems delivered good quality music but lost points with respect to sharpness in the mid frequency range. The Creative FPS 1000 generated an excusable amount of distortion and the Logitech delivered a lower quantity of mid frequencies but was definitely good at delivering even the lowest of frequencies. The Logitech Xtrusio is the right choice if you are interested in a PC sound system that can deliver good music quality.

The Typhoon DS1034, the Jetway Artis and the Frontech 5D-103 were capable of delivering an acceptable quality of music that will do well if you are not obsessed with getting perfect quality.



Logitech DSR100: A home theatre system with powerfull bass